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PACIFYING THE MARGINS

The Pa-O Self-Administered Zone and the Political Order in Southern Shan State

Ricky Yue

On 28 August 2014, a lieutenant colonel of the Restoration Council of Shan State/Shan State Army — South (RCSS/SSA-S) inspected land on top of a mountain he bought less than a year before for about US$10,000. The land has a commanding view of Taunggyi and Lake Inle. He said with excitement that a general in Yangon recently bought a similar plot adjacent to his for US$150,000. He added that once he had sufficient money, he would develop the site into a hotel. On the way back to Taunggyi town centre, his Toyota four-wheel drive was stopped by traffic police at an ad hoc checkpoint. He lowered the tinted glass and the police immediately recognized him. After exchanging a few words, the police made an apologetic gesture and waved the car on. The lieutenant colonel explained that they were stopping cars to fine those without the necessary permit. They stopped